

ZEN GARDEN

Peace and self-care

Level 1-4
15-30 mins

Wellness Domains

Spiritual, Emotional

Topic:

Self-care tool

Goals:

Participant creates and uses a self-care tool

Materials (Included/Subs):

- lunch tray, plastic dish, wooden frame
- sand
- 3-5 stones
- real or fake small plants like moss or grass
- rake, stick, chopstick, disposable fork
- Optional: battery-operated candle, small religious objects or tokens
- Optional: music, aromatherapy

Background:

Zen gardens are a type of garden that began in East Asia and later developed in Japan. They are made to be simple and calming. They often use sand, stones, water shapes, and small plants.

People use Zen gardens to slow down, relax, and focus their thoughts. Moving the sand or placing objects can help the body and mind feel calmer.

You do not need to be Buddhist or know anything about Zen to enjoy this activity. There is no right or wrong way but you can use the Zen design principles to guide them.

This activity supports mindfulness, reflection, and emotional calm.

Zen Design Ideas

- **Simplicity** – Use only what is needed
- **Balance** – Things do not have to match to feel right
- **Natural Feel** – Let things look natural, not perfect
- **Freedom** – Personal choices are welcome
- **Calm** – The goal is peace and quiet
- **Subtlety** – Small details can mean a lot
- **Time** – The garden can change over time

Structure / Activity:

Steps:

1. Play some soothing, instrumental music softly in the background.
2. Explain the activity- creating a personal zen table garden.
3. Briefly describe Zen gardens and how they can help with calm and focus. Use pictures if helpful.
4. Participant pours the sand into the tray and spread across the entire tray.
4. Participant chooses the stones and objects to incorporate into their garden.
5. Arrange each object on the tray in a way that feels right.
6. Use the tools to draw curves, swirls and patterns in the sand. Get creative!
7. Optional: Try a breathing or relaxation exercise with the garden.
8. Help them choose a safe, visible place to keep their new Zen garden!

Adaptations & Safety Precautions:

- Watch for signs of overwhelm (withdrawal, frustration, fatigue)
- This is not recommended for people with hyperorality or severe allergies